

History as Ornament

Prancing Horse Earrings
by Sunita Shekhawat

This fascinating story begins in the year 1614 when Mughal emperor Jahangir is gifted a Jacobean painting of a European nobleman by an envoy of the East India Company. Of all the jewels worn by the person in the painting, the emperor's eye catches a pendant in the shape of a horse—an English thoroughbred with a 'playful stride'. He wants that. The commissioned piece—a solid gold horse covered in lustrous ivory enamel, set with rubies and diamonds in a Baroque style—is created in Spain. The pendant never reaches the emperor. Passing through various collectors, it arrives at the Walters Art Museum in Baltimore, Maryland, the USA, in 2013. Fast forward to 2020. Sunita Shekhawat, a first-generation jeweller from Jodhpur, following her passion to revive and re-establish the lost practices and techniques of Minakari—enamel work jewellery that was introduced in India by the Mughals in the 16th century—sets out to recreate some of the best-known museum pieces of Minakari jewels for her Museum of Minakari Heritage (MOMH), that opened in Jaipur in March 2024. She comes across the 'Prancing Horse' and acquires rights to recreate the piece. Five artisans work on the piece for six months—drawing, moulding the form in gold, carving out the striations to fill the glass enamel, repeatedly firing the piece for setting the various hues—to recreate the jewel with 'Rondebosse', a 14th century French technique that involves three-dimensional coating of enamel all around the figure and selectively revealing the underlying gold as highlights. In June, Shekhawat made an adaptation of the Prancing Horse in the form of a pair of earrings for a private commission. Priced at ₹14.5 lakh, these are much more than ornaments. It is history prancing around the ear.

